

Foreign Policymaking (EA)

Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

Required reading: Ashbee, E. & Hurst, S. (2020), "The Trump foreign policy record and the concept of transformational change," *Global Affairs* 6(1): 5–19 · Putnam, R. (1988), "Diplomacy and Domestic Politics: The Logic of Two-Level Games," *International Organization* 42(3): 427–460 (to p.435). · Lecturer: Eddie Ashbee. (Putnam is CBS-library-only, not in the folder — the two-level-game section below is built from the deck + the standard framework; the win-set detail is the assigned part.)

Theme of the lecture. The IR theory lectures (I–IV) work mostly at the **international / state level** and treat what goes on *inside* a state as a "**black box**." This session **opens the box**: foreign policy is shaped by **domestic** as well as international variables, and the two **interact** — theorised through **neoclassical realism**, **Foreign Policy Analysis (FPA)**, and Putnam's "**two-level game**." The running case study is **US foreign policy since January 2017** — Trump and "Trumpism."

★ **The heart of the lecture:** foreign policy is **not** just a state responding to the international system — it is the **product of domestic politics interacting with international pressures**. IR's grand theories black-box the domestic; **FPA / neoclassical realism** open it, showing how **individuals, ideas, bureaucracies, interest groups and public opinion** shape policy. Putnam's **two-level game** models the interaction: a leader bargains **internationally (Level I)** and must get the deal **ratified at home (Level II)** at the same time. The **Trump** case tests whether a foreign-policy shift is "**transformational**" — a lasting change in **paradigm, interests, institutions and logics**.

The red thread. For any foreign-policy episode ask: *which domestic variables are in play, how do they interact with the international situation — and is the change **transformational** or just a passing shift?*

Key concepts / "modes" to use

- The "**black box**" — why grand IR theory sidelines domestic politics.
 - **Foreign Policy Analysis (FPA) / neoclassical realism** — systemic pressures **filtered through** domestic intervening variables.
 - **Domestic variables** — individuals · ideas/ideologies · bureaucratic cultures · interest groups & constituencies · public opinion (+ **salience**).
 - **Transformational change** (Ashbee & Hurst) — a lasting shift in **paradigm · interests · institutions · logics**.
 - **Embeddedness** — ideas rooted in supportive **interests + institutions** (weak embeddedness → only "proto-transformational").
 - **Two-level game** (Putnam) — Level I (international bargaining) + Level II (domestic ratification); **win-sets**; the **Schelling conjecture**.
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Opening the "black box" — why Foreign Policy Analysis? (deck)

Core: the main IR theories are **international- or state-level** — they largely **relegate or disregard** domestic processes, treating the state as a **"black box"** that responds to the system.

- **Structural realism (Waltz):** international relations are **anarchic**, trust is limited, so **any** state (autocracy or democracy) must **prioritise its own security & survival** and will act if it has the **capacities**. (*Domestic type barely matters.*)
- **Liberal internationalism (Ikenberry):** looks a little more inside — it cares about the **character of political systems** (democracies tend to avoid offensive wars — answerable to the public, tied by trade **interdependence**, cooperating through **IOs**; the tongue-in-cheek "**Golden Arches** theory" — no two countries with McDonald's fight). But it still doesn't examine **internal processes** closely.
- **Foreign Policy Analysis (FPA) & neoclassical realism** open the box: foreign policy = the **interaction of international structure and domestic processes** — not one or the other.

| Neoclassical realism — the bridge

Core: **neoclassical realism** keeps realism's **systemic** starting point (relative power, anarchy) but says those pressures are **filtered through domestic "intervening variables"** — leaders' perceptions, state–society relations, institutions — before they become policy. (*This is the neoclassical row of the realism family: "structure pushes, but domestic politics filters the push."*) → so **the same international pressure produces different policies** in different states, depending on the domestic filter. This is the theoretical warrant for spending the rest of the lecture on **domestic variables**.

★ Domestic variables that shape foreign policy (deck)

Core: five families of domestic variable — each a lens, none sufficient alone.

Variable	What it captures	Watch-outs / examples
Individuals / core actors	the " great man theory of history " (Carlyle: " <i>the history of the world is but the biography of great men</i> ") — leaders' beliefs, style, psychology	Trump (impulse control, short attention span). <i>But</i> focusing on individuals neglects structural forces (see below)
Ideas & ideologies ("belief systems")	the paradigm guiding policy — what problems/goals/instruments seem legitimate	Was Trump-I "standard Republican fare" (Reagan's "peace through strength") or a genuine break? (<i>the debate the reading settles</i>)
Bureaucratic cultures & sub-cultures	agencies' standing operating cultures; coalitions & factions inside the executive	State Dept vs Defense vs intelligence — "trade hawks" vs finance factions under Trump
Interest groups & constituencies	lobbying, campaigning, campaign contributions, the "revolving door" — and geographic constituencies (e.g. rust-belt states)	note instrumental power (direct lobbying) vs structural power (business's leverage over investment/jobs)
Public opinion	mass attitudes constraining leaders (e.g. Vietnam disengagement blamed on unpopularity)	★ salience : except in acute crisis or heavy losses , public engagement with foreign policy is usually LOW (Durant & Diehl 1989)

- **The structural counterweight (deck)**: an individual-only focus **underestimates context**. Trump's mercurial style was *enabled* by the **relative weakness of checks & balances** in the foreign-policy arena — plus deeper trends: **party polarisation, party homogenisation**, and a **populist shift**. (Cf. *Truman (1945–53) leading the US into international engagement — a mix of individual commitment + shifts in economic elites + strategic pressure from the USSR: several variables at once.*)

★ Case study — US foreign policy since 2017 (Ashbee & Hurst 2020)

▮ The paradigm Trump inherited

Core: to judge whether Trump is a *break*, you must know what he broke *from*. US foreign policy ran on **Liberal Internationalism (LI)** — itself the product of the **1940s transformation** — which then fragmented.

- **Liberal Internationalism (LI)** — after WWII the US committed to **open-ended international engagement + global leadership**, building the **UN, IMF, World Bank, GATT, NATO** and a domestic **national-security state** (National Security Act 1947 → DoD, Joint Chiefs, NSC, CIA). (*This is the reading's model of a completed transformation — see below.*)
- **Fragmentation from the 1970s**: LI split. Some (mainly **Democrats**) rejected the **use of force**; another grouping (mainly **Republicans**) rejected LI's **cooperative** side → **militant / conservative internationalism = primacism** (US primacy, "hard" power used **unilaterally** or in **coalitions of the willing**, sidelining the UN/multilateralism) **but** keeping a **moral purpose** — faith in **democracy &**

freedom (Bush's Iraq war, democracy promotion, nation-building, regime change) and trade liberalisation. This paradigm **weakened from ~2006**.

- **2016 — MAGA**: a populist reaction to "**elite projects**" and perceived **US decline**, addressing both domestic and foreign policy.

■ **Trump's first term (2017–21) — the populist-nationalist break**

Core: Trump = **primacism + economic nationalism + "principled realism"** — i.e. conservative internationalism **minus the moral purpose**. The reading distils a **populist-nationalist paradigm** of **five propositions**:

1. **The nation is core** — defined by **ethnicity/culture**, not ideals/principles (Bannon: "a nation with a culture — and a reason for being").
 2. **Zero-sum competition** — nations are locked in a **struggle for hegemony**; limited scope for cooperation (the 2017 National Security Strategy used "competition" **18 times**); the US has been "losing."
 3. **Anti-"globalism"** — the nation & its people have suffered from **globalism** and global elites ("the party of Davos").
 4. **Trade subordinated to the nation** — markets should serve national purposes; hostility to **NAFTA/TPP**; prefer **bilateral ("one-on-one") deals** where US preponderance wins; reject **multilateral** trade liberalisation.
 5. **Moral vision abandoned** — no more Reagan's "shining city" or Bush's freedom agenda; **rejects regime change / democracy promotion** ("we are not here to lecture").
- **In practice**: challenging **China**; **transactionalism**; negotiations with **Russia & North Korea**; **unilateralism**; **burden-sharing** demands on allies; doubts about **collective security (NATO)**; **protectionism**.

■ ★ **Was it transformational? — the Ashbee & Hurst framework**

Core: the paper's real contribution is a **precise definition of transformational change** (drawing on **Polanyi**, historical institutionalism, Skowronek). Transformational change = a **lasting shift across four linked elements** — not just dramatic-but-passing change.

Element	What must shift	LI (1940s) — the model	Trump (2017+) — the "first cut"
Paradigm	the framework of ideas/goals/instruments (Hall) — until new ideas become " common sense "	open-ended engagement & liberal world order	populist-nationalist paradigm (anti-globalism, bilateralism, no moral purpose) — but only "common sense" to the base
Interests	new interests grip power; new coalitions (Skowronek)	New-Deal coalition + "Wall Street" Republicans sideline isolationists	FP "establishment" & peak business sidelined ; GOP base shifts to non-college white workers
Institutions	formal & informal institutional re-ordering	UN/IMF/NATO + the national-security state	withdrawals (Paris, TPP, UNESCO, UN HR Council), undermining the WTO , gutting the State Dept/IC — <i>but</i> core alliances remain intact
Logics	new chains of events /incentives that endure (path dependence)	enduring collective-security commitments	weakened trans-Atlanticism; allies edge toward self-reliance ; TPP revived without the US

- ★ **The verdict:** applying the framework gives a **mixed picture** — the **beginnings of transformational change**, but "**incipient, partial and variegated**." The **ideational** shift is the most dramatic; institutional/interest shifts are real but **incomplete**; logics are hardest to read this early.

★ Embeddedness — why "proto-transformational"

Core: ideas only become a *lasting* transformation when they are **embedded** — i.e. **rooted in supportive interests and institutions** (so they outlive the leader). Trump's first-term primacism was **pursued inconsistently and weakly embedded** (he **marginalised** the national-security bureaucracy but did **not** rebuild it into a self-sustaining machine for the new paradigm) → only "**proto-transformational**."

- Two reasons it may not stick (reading):** (1) **populism is a "thin" ideology** (Mudde) — a **crust** on top of other ideologies, so the administration could be pulled **back** toward conservative/militant internationalism; (2) the US remains **locked into** its key post-war security institutions.

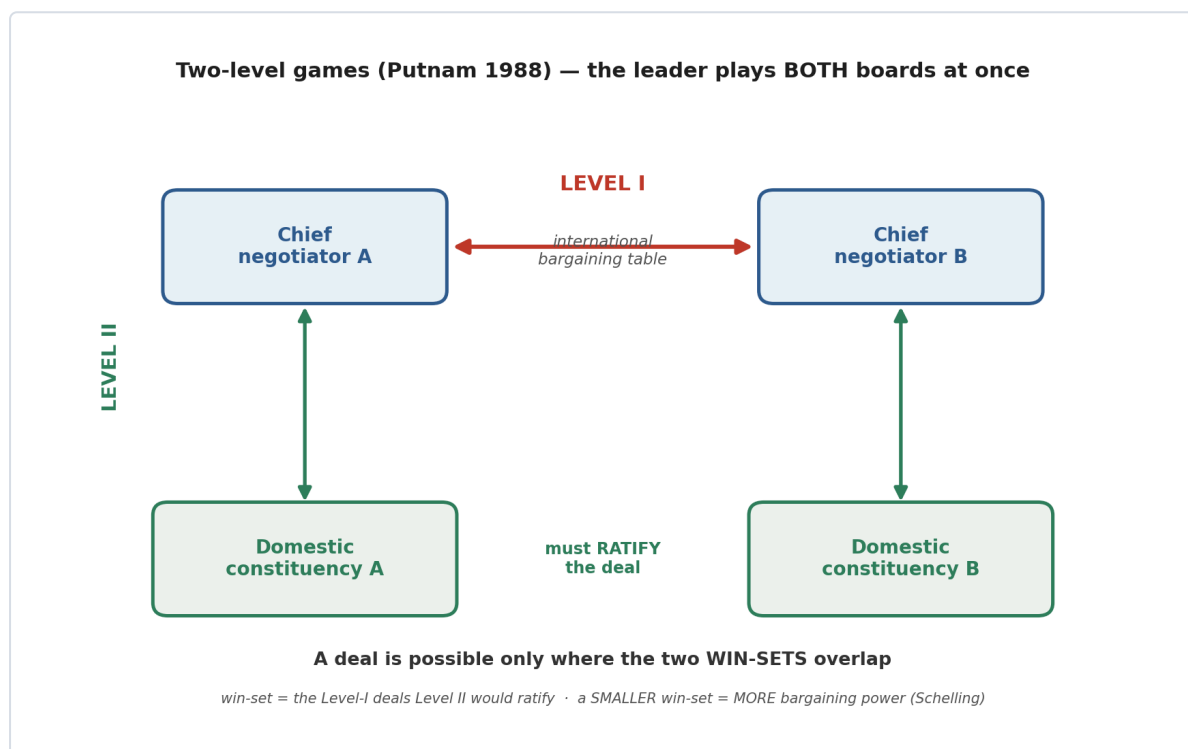
Second term (2025+) & the Democrats (*deck*)

- Trump II / the GOP:** no single guiding ideology — pulled between rival **ideational clusters**. But some **constants** ("**floating ideas**") cut across the divisions: **support for Israel** (note the role of **religious conservatism** in the party), **disdain for Europe** + support for "patriotic" forces; **2026** sees growing divisions (e.g. **Iran**).
- Democrats:** no clear foreign-policy orientation; Biden's "**alliance of democracies**" gained limited traction; continued **opposition to China** + **support for Ukraine**; increasingly **divided over Israel/Palestine (Gaza)** (DNC vs DSA); 2028 wide open.

★ How do domestic & international variables interact? — the two-level game (Putnam 1988)

Core: domestic and international variables clearly interact — but *on what terms?* (avoid analytical "ad-hocery"). Putnam's answer: an international negotiation is a **single game played simultaneously at two interconnected levels**.

- **Level I** = bargaining between the negotiators at the international table.
- **Level II** = separate discussions inside each country about whether to **ratify** what the negotiator brings home.
- The leader sits at **both boards at once**: a deal must be **struck internationally** *and* **ratifiable domestically**.



How to read it. The key concept is the win-set = *the set of all Level-I deals that would win ratification at Level II*. Two consequences:

- A deal is possible only where the two win-sets **overlap** — bigger win-sets make agreement **more likely** (but risk a deal your public dislikes).
- ★ **The Schelling conjecture (the counter-intuitive bit):** a smaller win-set can give a negotiator **more bargaining power** — "I'd love to accept, but my parliament will never ratify that" forces the other side to move. Being **tied down at home** is a **bargaining asset** abroad.
- **Defection:** a deal can fail through **voluntary** defection (a rational leader reneges) or **involuntary** defection (the leader *can't deliver* because ratification fails at home). → *domestic and international politics are entangled, not separate*.

| Or does the balance *vary*? (deck)

Core: an alternative to "it's always a two-level game" is that the **weight** of domestic vs international variables **varies systematically** — by:

- **Time-period** — domestic variables matter **less in acute crisis** (power centralises, the public rallies).
 - **State size** — **small states** may have **fewer foreign-policy options** (more constrained by the system).
 - **Regime type** — **liberal democracies** are arguably **more exposed to domestic pressures** than illiberal/authoritarian states.
 - **Policy arena** — some issues draw **much more domestic engagement** — most notably **trade**.
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Cases & examples

- **The 1940s Liberal-Internationalism transformation.** Paradigm (global leadership) + interests (New-Deal/Wall-Street coalition) + institutions (UN/IMF/NATO + national-security state) + enduring logics. → *Illustrates: a **completed** transformational change — the model Trump is measured against.*
- **Trump-era US foreign policy (2017+).** Populist-nationalist paradigm, sidelined establishment, withdrawals from agreements, gutted State Dept — but intact alliances. → *Illustrates: "**incipient, partial and variegated**" transformation; **weak embeddedness** → proto-transformational.*
- **Vietnam disengagement.** Blamed on rising unpopularity — but note **salience** (opinion bites mainly under heavy losses). → *Illustrates: **public opinion** as a domestic variable, and its limits.*
- **Truman & international engagement (1945–53).** Individual commitment + elite shifts + USSR pressure. → *Illustrates: foreign policy as **several domestic + international variables interacting.***

Key terms

Term	Meaning
"Black box"	Grand IR theory treats the state's internal politics as unopened — inputs (system) → outputs (policy)
Foreign Policy Analysis (FPA)	The study of foreign policy as a product of domestic processes + international structure
Neoclassical realism	Systemic pressures filtered through domestic intervening variables (leaders, institutions)
Salience	How much the public actually attends to an issue (usually low for foreign policy)
Instrumental vs structural power	Direct lobbying vs business's leverage from control over investment/jobs
Transformational change	Lasting shift in paradigm · interests · institutions · logics (Ashbee & Hurst / Polanyi)
Embeddedness	Ideas rooted in supportive interests + institutions → they endure beyond the leader
Primacism	US primacy /preponderance as the organising aim of foreign policy
Two-level game (Putnam)	A negotiation played simultaneously at Level I (international) + Level II (domestic ratification)
Win-set	The set of Level-I deals that would be ratified at Level II; deals need overlapping win-sets
Schelling conjecture	A smaller win-set (tied hands at home) can mean more bargaining power abroad

Exam pointers

- Explain the **"black box"** critique and how **neoclassical realism / FPA** open it (systemic pressure **filtered through** domestic variables).
- List and apply the **five domestic variables** — and the **salience** caveat on public opinion.
- Define **transformational change** by its **four elements** (paradigm/interests/institutions/logics) and run it on **Trump** — verdict: **"incipient, partial and variegated"**; explain **embeddedness** and why Trump-I was only **proto-transformational**.
- Set out the **two-level game** (Level I/II, win-sets, the **Schelling conjecture**, voluntary vs involuntary defection).
- Give the **four ways the domestic–international balance may vary** (time/crisis, state size, regime type, policy arena — esp. **trade**).

Bridge. This lecture is the **hinge** between IR theory (I–IV) and real foreign-policy **practice**: the grand theories set the *international* stage, but **who a state actually is at home** — its leaders, ideas, bureaucracies, interests and publics — decides how it plays. The **two-level game** is the model of that interaction; **transformational change** is the yardstick for whether a shift will last.

★ Fun facts & memorable details (Foreign Policymaking)

Sticky bits from the foreign-policymaking lecture.

- The "**Golden Arches**" **theory of peace**: no two countries that both have **McDonald's** had ever fought a war (a jokey stand-in for the liberal claim that **trade interdependence** deters war).
- "**The history of the world is but the biography of great men**" (Carlyle, 1840) — the **great-man theory** the lecture uses to *set up* why leaders alone aren't enough.
- **Tied hands are a bargaining chip**: Putnam/Schelling's counter-intuitive point — "*my parliament will never ratify that*" can win you a **better** deal. Weakness at home = strength abroad.
- The 2017 US National Security Strategy used the word "**competition**" **18 times** — the reading's neat evidence of the zero-sum, nationalist paradigm shift.
- A "**hostile takeover**": a departing senior diplomat described Trump's first-year State Department — "*you decapitate the leadership, you compartmentalize the power centers, you engender fear and suspicion.*"
- **Populism is a "thin" ideology** (Mudde) — a **crust** on top of other ideologies, which is why Ashbee & Hurst call Trump-I only "**proto-transformational**."
- **Japan revived the TPP *without* the US** after Trump pulled out — a real "changed logic": the world starts building around, not through, Washington.